

Surprised, but trusting the Pythia, Cadmus and his men set off into the fields around Delphi. Sure enough, they soon spotted a cow with a half-moon mark and followed it across the hills. Finally, it slumped down, exhausted.

Cadmus decided to sacrifice the cow to the goddess Athena. He sent some men to fetch water for the ceremony, but when they arrived at the local well they found it guarded by a fearsome dragon.

*Cadmus took it upon himself to slay the beast.*

Cadmus and the dragon fought sword against claw, but eventually Cadmus saw his opportunity and sliced off the monster's head. Triumphant, he collected the water and returned to his men. What he did not realize was that this was the Ismenian dragon, a child of Ares, the god of war.

Ares was angry and upset. Desperate for the god's forgiveness, Cadmus offered to serve Ares for as long as he needed. For eight long years, Cadmus obeyed Ares' every command, until finally the god released him.

Athena, however, had not forgotten Cadmus's sacrifice. She decided to help him build a city where the cow had died. Cadmus never found his sister Europa, but he did establish the great city of Thebes.

*Cadmus built the mighty city of Thebes.*

